



The digital logic unit of the NORC



The console unit of the IBM 650

December: The first “supercomputer”

The NORC (Naval Ordnance Research Calculator) was delivered to the US Navy. It was the first computer to have been called a supercomputer; it could perform 15,000 arithmetical calculations in one second. Its first demonstration was to calculate the value of pi, which it calculated to an accuracy of 3,089 digits, a record at that time. The NORC was used for complicated operations like calculation of missile trajectories and plotting the orbits earth and other

A Bit About Supercomputers

Supercomputers are giant computers, both in size and processing power. They are used for tasks that require extensive processing capabilities like weather forecasting, analysis of geological data for petroleum processing, molecular modelling, nuclear energy research, and cryptanalysis. Supercomputers today measure their speed in TeraFLOPS (trillions of floating point operations per second), with the fastest supercomputer as of June 2007 being BlueGene/L, with a speed of 280.6 teraflops. Seymour Cray's series of supercomputers are the best known, though IBM and HP are among the other makers. India's PARAM series, built by CDAC, is our home-grown supercomputers; PARAM 10000 is at 1 teraflop, while CDAC plans to build a 1 PetaFLOP (1,000 trillion FLOPS) unit in 2010.